

and the way you rule. Depending on the level of taxes that you levy, which range from 'small bribes' to 'no taxes' to 'mean taxes', your population will increase or decrease. As your popularity increases so will the number of people coming to work and living in your castle. You can check your status reports, such as food stocks, by clicking on the scribe whose facial expressions indicate your popularity level! The scribe also gives you instructions and calls out warnings while playing the military campaigns.

You start off by choosing an appropriate location for your keep, around which you must build your town and castle. To begin with you have a default amount of resources but you must soon go about building up on your stockpile of food and wood. However, unlike AOE these tasks are more detailed in *Stronghold*. For example, a woodcutter



The graphics in *Stronghold* feature variable points of view

chops wood and carries it to his hut to saw them into planks, which he then carries to the stockpile. Similarly, your fletcher won't start making weapons until he carries wood over from your stockpile to his workshop! Just a few examples of the attempts to add realism to what would otherwise be another

medieval castle building game. Your main enemies are some pretty shady characters; Duke de Puce (The Rat), Duke Beauregard (The Snake), Duke Truffle (The Pig), and Duke Volpe (The Wolf), who rule the neighbouring lands. In the multiplayer mode *Stronghold* supports up to eight players on a LAN or Internet connection.

Aside from its unbearable manual, which is predominantly in Hindi interspersed with game terms in English, this game is definitely a must play for strategy fans. In summary, a treat for the real time strategy lover who can't afford *Age of Empires*.

Genre: Strategy
Developer: Firefly Studios Limited
Distributor: e-xpress Interactive Software
Phone: 91-022-88700175
Web site: www.fireflyworlds.com
Price: Rs 699
Rating: ★★★★★

Command and Conquer: Renegade Renaissance

Command and Conquer (C&C): Renegade takes the Real Time Strategy (RTS) series down the First Person Shooter (FPS) path, with entertaining results.

The C&C franchise started in 1995, and since then has produced some of the most successful real-time strategy games. But unlike previous incarnations, *C&C Renegade* treads new ground—this is the first time Westwood has come out with a first-person shooter.

This game continues the tradition of the C&C series, and delves again into the struggle between GDI and the Brotherhood of Nod. The game puts you in the role of 'Havoc', based on the Commando unit of the original game. Havoc has now been reincarnated to embody your macho, beefy, take-no-prisoners action hero.

The battle, essentially, is for control of the planet and the dwindling power source known as Tiberium. Nod leader Kane has been experimenting with Tiberium and created mutant super-soldiers. Havoc, with an ensemble of other characters, has to stop him. You will get the opportunity to drive several vehicles, collect a wide variety of weapons, and shoot an endless stream of bad guys. The FPS aspect of this game features power-

ups and weapons that you collect as you go on.

Once you are into a mission, the game plays well. The game uses scripted events, radio transmissions, and staged battles to simulate the feel of being on a 'real' C&C battlefield. Graphically, *Renegade* looks somewhat dated, especially when you consider that its system specifications asks for a better system than what *Max Payne* and *Wolfenstein* do! Still, it's a good showing for a non-Quake III derived engine.

Multiplayer consists of Deathmatch and Capture the Flag modes, but where it finally leaves its mark is the Command and Conquer mode. This mode pits the forces of NOD against the GDI army, whereby the match is won once all of either side's buildings are destroyed or a beacon of mass destruction is placed on a certain pedestal. The game feels like *Tribes 2*, and is an absolute blast to play, easily rivalling the current crop of online FPS games.

Renegade is fast and furious fun; mowing down enemies and blasting things is mindless fun. The only drawback of the game is the AI; the enemies run straight into a gun sometimes and stand immobile at other times.



Havoc guns down on NOD troops

Overall, the title is a little pricey, but coming from Westwood and EA, good production values are assured. While the single player version of the game has its drawbacks, the strong multiplayer aspect of the game carries it through. Fans of the *Command and Conquer* series should give this one a look.

Genre: FPS/Action
Developer: Westwood
Distributor: Origin Marketing
Phone: 91-022-8801335
Web site: www.cncrenegade.com
Price: Rs 1,290
Rating: ★★★★★